I leaned forward. Maybe not quite gold.

No, maybe it was more yellow.

Yes. Yellow ear plugs.

I looked into my lap and smiled. When I lifted my head again, I watched with glee as Granny kept time to music she couldn't hear, or music she'd found a clever and subtle way of…distancing. Controlling.

More than ever before, I wanted to give my Granny a hug.

38.

I SAT DOWN WITH PA that summer, possibly at Balmoral, though it might've been Clarence House, where he was now living more or less full-time. He'd moved in shortly after Gan-Gan's death, and wherever he lived, I lived.

When I wasn't living at Manor House.

My final year at Eton drawing near, Pa wanted to chat about how I envisaged my life post-Eton. Most of my mates would be headed off to university. Willy was already at St. Andrews and thriving. Henners had just finished his A levels at Harrow School and was planning to go to Newcastle.

And you, darling boy? Have you given any thought to…the future?

Why, yes. Yes, I had. For several years I'd talked in all seriousness about working at the ski resort in Lech am Arlberg, where Mummy used to take us. Such wonderful memories. Specifically, I wanted to work at the fondue hut in the center of town, which Mummy loved. That fondue could change your life. (I really was that mad.) But now I told Pa I'd given up the fondue fantasy, and he sighed with relief.

Instead I was taken with notions of becoming a ski instructor…

Pa tensed again. *Out of the question.*

OK.

Long pause.

How about…safari guide?

No, darling boy.

This wasn't going to be easy.